

U.S. Census Bureau has shown that for the 1.7 million custodial parents who do not receive child support, their annual income was only \$23,400. This puts them only slightly above the 2004 poverty level of \$18,850 for a family of four.

Franklin couldn't believe that his two largest debt obligations would always follow him. His bankruptcy only served to eliminate several of his smaller credit card debts. Now he had a bankruptcy, which would appear on his credit report for ten years, and no relief from his child support and student loan obligations. Following his pattern of always evading his responsibilities, Franklin decided to leave the country. His self-imposed exile left his money troubles behind him, but so too did he leave his child, friends, and country.

The only way for this story to have a happy ending (unless exile in a foreign land is considered a happy ending), would be for Franklin to take responsibility for his actions. Without admitting and accepting responsibility, Franklin would continue to run away from his obligations until he got caught. His pattern of owing money through student loans, child support, and credit card bills had become a habit. So too had his pattern of not paying his debts.

Franklin had convinced himself that he wasn't obligated to pay off these debts so he tried to ignore them. When he couldn't ignore them anymore, he tried to use the same legal system to his advantage by filing bankruptcy. Unfortunately, this remedy did not eliminate all his debts, as he had believed it would.

Additionally, for those who view bankruptcy as a tool they can utilize repeatedly whenever the going gets tough, a provision in the Bankruptcy Reform Law states that after filing a bankruptcy, the person cannot file a subsequent bankruptcy for eight years. So during this time period, bankruptcy is not an option if they get into financial hot water again.

